

SIX OPENINGS

Six ways of starting the same episode of a true crime podcast. Same case, same facts, same narrator. Only the way in is different. Each is about a minute read aloud.

Have them read to you rather than reading them yourself, and sit with each one for a few seconds before saying anything.

They are not in order of preference, nobody's name is on them, and there is no right answer.

One

ALLY. Del Cruz has called me Quinny since I was thirteen, since the night she stood on our doorstep with the news that my father was dead. She's police, so she doesn't hand me things. She points. When I said I'd been asking around about the city's cold cases, she pointed me at a list the city publishes and nobody reads. The people Havenbay buried without names.

November. A woman in her thirties, dead at the foot of the wet steps under the Stonebridge Viaduct. One injury, the back of the head. The city decided she fell. Eleven lines. I counted.

Tuesday night, a caller gave me a twelfth. The woman's name was Kerry. She didn't fall. She hit her head in her own room, and a man carried her down to those steps. Then somebody behind the caller said a name, and the message ended.

If the twelfth line is true, only one person could have told her. Him. She knows what he did. She lives close enough to hear him coming. And I cannot call her back.

Two

ALLY. It took me two days to find somebody who might be missing a Kerry.

Her name is Maureen Nolan. She lives interstate, and she has paid her daughter's phone bill every month since November. The number rings out. She leaves messages anyway. She told me they have all turned into the same message by now, which is that she isn't angry and she would just like to know she's all right.

Her daughter has been dead since November.

She is in a file in this city under five words. Unidentified female, no fixed address. Found at the bottom of the steps under the Stonebridge Viaduct with one injury to the back of her head, and this city wrote down that she fell.

Here is what I actually have. On Tuesday night a woman I have never met left a message saying Kerry didn't fall, that she hit her head in a room and that a man carried her out afterwards. Then somebody in the corridor said her name and she hung up.

I don't know if she was telling me the truth.

I know that if she was, she is sleeping tonight beside the man who did it, and I have no idea where that is.

Three

ALLY. Eight months ago, a cleaner vanished from the Hart Civic Center. An unidentified woman was found dead below Stonebridge the next morning.

At six twelve Thursday night, the cleaner who replaced her sent this text.

"Mrs. Coal, I will not be returning. Please send my final fortnight's wages to my home address. I leave Havenbay Friday."

Her supervisor showed me the screen.

SUPERVISOR. She calls me Jan. And she knows how to spell my name.

ALLY. Last night, the tip line caught a frightened woman saying her boyfriend killed Kerry in a room and moved her to the Stonebridge steps. A door opened. A man called her Leah. She hung up.

The old roster gave me two names. Kerry Nolan stopped arriving eight months ago. Leah Mercer sent Thursday's message.

Those facts fit. Neat facts worry me.

I do not know whether Leah wrote the text, whether Kerry is the dead woman, or whether any murder happened at all.

I know somebody using Leah's phone says she will be gone by Friday.

Four

ALLY. On Thursday I stood in Rivermouth, under the window of a room where a woman may have died.

In November, a woman was found dead at the foot of the Stonebridge Viaduct steps, one injury to the back of her head, and the city called it a fall. On Tuesday, a caller told our tip line the dead woman's name was Kerry, that she died in a room in Rivermouth, and that a man carried her out. Then she heard footsteps and hung up.

So I walked Rivermouth. A landlord remembered a tenant named Kerry who stopped paying in November. He boxed her things and kept them by the stairs in case she came back. Nobody came.

Our tip line keeps a voice, a date and a time. I don't know if she told me the truth. If she did, only one man could have told her about that room, and I think the footsteps she heard were his. Kerry took me two days to find. I don't know how to find the living one.

Five

A tone. A recorded message begins.

RECORDING. *A woman, quiet, close to the phone.* The woman they found under Stonebridge had a name. It was Kerry. She didn't fall down those steps. He told me she hit her head in her own room and that he moved her afterwards. That's never been in the news.

A door opens somewhere behind her. Keys.

A MAN, distant. Leah?

RECORDING. I have to go.

The message ends.

ALLY. I played that back eleven times. On the eleventh I said "where are you" out loud, in an empty studio, at one in the morning, to a woman who had recorded it four hours earlier and was not there.

Our tip line keeps three things. A voice, a date, a time. It doesn't keep numbers, because I promised it wouldn't, and that promise is the only reason anybody uses it.

So Tuesday night left me with a dead woman who has no surname, a living woman who has no address, and a man who has probably already looked at her phone.

Six

ALLY. Woman, about thirty-four. Found dead below the wet steps at Stonebridge. No name. No address. The file says she fell.

Last night, an anonymous caller said it was murder.

She said the dead woman was called Kerry. She said her boyfriend killed Kerry in a room, moved her under the viaduct, and knew the fall would look ordinary. Then a door opened behind her. A man called her Leah. The message ended.

That is everything the tip line kept. One voice. Tuesday. Eleven eighteen. No number to call back, because anonymity is the promise that makes people call at all.

I do not know whether Kerry existed. I do not know whether Leah was frightened, mistaken, or setting a match to somebody else's life. I know a woman died eight months ago and Havenbay never found her name. Now another woman may be leaving with a man who may know it.

The file gives me one fact to start with.

No fixed address.

Questions

1. **Which one do you need to hear the rest of?** First instinct.
2. **Which one would you switch off?**
3. **Would you come back tomorrow for the one you picked?**
4. **Was there one you didn't believe?** That is as useful as the one you liked.

Answer those four first. Anything else you want to say is welcome afterwards.